



to present-day Alaska. Later, they spread across the continent and formed separate groups. Today, surviving American Indians communities vary widely, both in their customs and rituals, and in the degree to which

they have preserved their traditional ways. Many exploit the widespread interest in their history by becoming involved in the tourist trade—often by selling objects they produce using unique and time-honored craft skills.



IMAGE AND REALITY

The Sioux Nation is the most like Hollywood Indians. Together with the Cheyenne, these Plains people defeated the 7th US Cavalry at Little Big Horn in 1876, killing its leader, General Custer. In 1890, Custer's men took revenge when they slaughtered the Sioux at Wounded Knee, South Dakota. These modern descendants are visiting the site, which has come to symbolize Indian rights.

WEARING THE PAST

Historical Sioux dress involves many of the elements associated with American Indian clothing: feathered headdresses, fringed leather, beadwork, quillwork, and moccasins. Today, most American Indians wear casual clothing for every day, and save their full regalia for ceremonial occasions or tourist display.



PRINCIPAL PEOPLE

Native to the Southeast region, the Cherokee Nation—who, in their own language, call themselves the “principal people”—practice a number of traditional crafts, perhaps the best known of which is basket-making; they are also skilled potters, carvers, and weavers.



CHEROKEE CHIEF

Principal Chief of the Cherokee Nation of Oklahoma from 1985 to 1995, Wilma Mankiller was the first female in modern history to lead a major American Indian people. Her family name is an old military title given to the honored figure entrusted with protecting a Cherokee village.



LIVING HISTORY

This re-created Cherokee settlement in North Carolina provides a popular attraction for tourists, and helps the people to preserve their centuries-old heritage. Here, a young Cherokee girl uses traditional skills and designs to weave a collection of colorful belts.

